

INTELLIGENCE BRIEF / N° 254 · HOT

Walden Robotics

General-Purpose Robotics · Factory Automation · Cambridge, Massachusetts · Private (\$1.1B; \$300M seed, Jul 2026)

Walden Robotics, the Toyota Research Institute spin-out whose wheeled, two-armed robots have worked a Toyota plant floor since February, came out of stealth on 15 July with a \$300M seed at a \$1.1B valuation, co-led by Toyota and Deviation Capital, with Nvidia, Boeing and Samsung Ventures behind it.

70

OPPORTUNITY / 100

TIMING WINDOW

HOT

SERIES

F1

RECOMMENDED TEAM

TGR Haas F1 Team

ACTION HORIZON

6-10 WKS

THE CASE

The company was founded in January 2026 out of Toyota Research Institute by Russ Tedrake, the MIT professor who ran TRI's large-behavior-model work. Its robots have two arms and a sensor head on a wheeled base, no legs, and run on Large Behavior Models that learn a task through practice. At a Toyota plant in North America they went from first pilot to production in under two months and now run shifts alongside human teams: machine tending, tool setting, parts kitting, loading and unloading. Strategic partners span automotive, aerospace, semiconductors, electronics and logistics.

No robotics brand sits on the 2026 F1 grid, and the one team titled by Walden's lead investor runs its own CNC shop: Haas is owned by Gene Haas, founder of Haas Automation, the largest CNC machine-tool builder in North America. Machine tending is the task Walden's robots already do at Toyota. The lane is open and the workstream is literal.

WHY NOW

The seed closed on 15 July and the deployments it funds are the story; a company hiring against a \$300M cheque needs a stage engineers watch. Teams close 2027 rosters in the fourth quarter, Austin and Las Vegas sit inside the window, and the winter build is when a factory pilot runs.

PROOF POINTS — EVERY FIGURE VERIFIED TO A PRIMARY SOURCE (SEE P.2)

\$300M

\$300M seed at a \$1.1B valuation announced 15 Jul 2026, co-led by Toyota (Toyota Motor Corporation, Toyota I...

\$1.1B

funding round: valued at \$1.1B on 15 Jul 2026 by a \$300M seed, out of stealth six months after spinning out...

GRID FIT — CATEGORY-WHITESPACE CHECK ACROSS THE F1 GRID (SPONSOR TABLE; 85 OF 347 PARTNER ROWS CATEGORISED)

TGR Haas F1 Team	OPEN	no rival in this category lane
Oracle Red Bull Racing	TAKEN	Siemens
Visa Cash App Racing Bulls	TAKEN	Siemens
Mercedes-AMG Petronas F1 Team	OPEN	no rival in this category lane

BOTTOM LINE

\$300M at \$1.1B on 15 July, robots at work in a Toyota plant since February, the Toyota-titled team with its own CNC shop, and no robotics brand on the grid. No marketing chief and a two-month-old trigger hold it at 70.

- FUNDING EVENT
- CATEGORY OPEN
- INVESTOR LINK
- DISCOVERY: SCAN

WHY TGR HAAS F1 TEAM

Toyota Gazoo Racing took the title at Haas from 2026 after a 2024 technical partnership, and Toyota co-led Walden's seed: the introduction runs through the investor. Haas is the American privateer, based in Kannapolis and Banbury, with a CNC shop at the centre of its operations. Formula E is closed to the category: ABB, a robotics and automation group, has been its title partner since 2018. Carmaker-aligned teams are awkward for a Toyota-backed company; Williams is the only other independent.

VALUE TO TGR HAAS F1 TEAM — MODE A (TECH IN THE CAR / CHAMPIONSHIP)

MODE A. Walden robots on the Kannapolis and Banbury floors doing what they do at Toyota: tending the team's CNC machines, tool setting, kitting parts for the car build and loading between stations, on a pilot-to-production cycle Toyota ran in under two months. In return: Official Robotics Partner designation, sidepod and garage presence, Austin and Las Vegas hospitality for the manufacturers Walden sells to, and a content series.

DEAL ARCHITECTURE

Entry as Official Robotics Partner. **THREE YEARS**, 2027-2029, spanning the first deployments beyond Toyota and two car builds. Estimated \$3-5M a year, part-payable in robot deployments the team would otherwise staff. Scope: sidepod placement, naming of the Kannapolis robot cell, Austin and Las Vegas hospitality, and a factory content series.

PRIMARY DECISION-MAKER

Russ Tedrake
CO-FOUNDER AND CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER, WALDEN ROBOTICS
· **VERIFIED**

Tedrake is an MIT professor who spent a decade at Toyota Research Institute, latterly senior vice president of large behavior models. No chief marketing officer is listed. Path: Adrien Gaidon, co-founder and Chief Strategy Officer; Ben Burchfiel, co-founder and Chief Technology Officer; Dave Johnson, Chief Product Officer.

OPENING ANGLE

Lead with the CNC shop, not the logo.

“Russ, your lead investor's racing arm puts its name on the one F1 team that runs its own CNC shop, your robots already tend Toyota's machines, and nobody on the grid has a robotics partner. 25 minutes before Austin?”

SCORE COMPOSITION

TIMING 14 / 20 Seed 15 Jul; Austin, Las Vegas and the winter build in window.	CAPACITY 16 / 20 \$300M at \$1.1B; a seed for deployments, not marketing.	BRAND FIT 13 / 20 Factory robots are motorsport-native; the Toyota tie carries it.	URGENCY 13 / 20 Hiring and credibility; no launch or listing date.	OPS FIT 14 / 20 MODE A: machine tending and kitting at Kannapolis, Banbury.
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RISKS & COUNTERS

A SEED-STAGE MARKETING BUDGET The \$300M funds robots and deployments; no chief marketing officer or marketing function owns a sponsorship. **Counter:** Enter at partner tier, part-paid in deployments; sell it as a reference customer and a recruiting stage.

TOYOTA'S PORTFOLIO, NOT ITS BRAND Toyota is an investor, not the owner; a Walden logo on a TGR-titled car needs TGR's comfort. **Counter:** Open through the investor; Williams is the fallback if TGR declines.

SOURCES — 12 OF 12 LOAD-BEARING CLAIMS VERIFIED

- <https://www.bostonglobe.com/2026/07/15/business/walden-robotics-cambridge-toyota-humanoid/>
- [https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20260715089377/en/Walden-Robotics-Launches-with-\\$300-Million-to-Put-General-Purpose-Robots-to-Work-Today](https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20260715089377/en/Walden-Robotics-Launches-with-$300-Million-to-Put-General-Purpose-Robots-to-Work-Today)
- <https://global.toyota/en/newsroom/corporate/41645635.html>